

with his *tezcātl*, a polished mirror made of obsidian. Much used for black magic in ancient Mexico, the black mirror was associated with dark forces and may have symbolized Tezcatlipoca's all-seeing powers. He appeared in numerous guises, both good and bad: in some, he was believed to work black magic, and he also embodied, among other things, the wind and the night.

The god Quetzalcoatl took the form of a plumed serpent, with feathers from the local—sacred—quetzal bird. Snakes and serpents in general were believed to have magical and divinatory powers. Among other attributes, Quetzalcoatl was credited with inventing the calendar, which was a vital tool of Aztec divination. Through his association with the morning and evening stars, Quetzalcoatl also symbolized death and resurrection.

Shape-shifting transformations

Both gods and humans were thought to shape-shift into animals to perform various magical acts. Tezcatlipoca's animal form was the jaguar. Such animal spirits—often seen as protective helpers—were called *naguals*. This echoes ideas of witches' animal “familiar” that were widespread in Western folk magic at this time (see pp.186–187).

“The night, the wind,
the sorcerer, our lord.”

FRIAR BERNARDINO DE SAHAGÚN

ON TEZCATLIPOCA, *FLORENTINE CODEX*, c. 1540–1585



The colorful snout decoration suggests feathers—a visual link with Quetzalcoatl

The teeth in each of the two open mouths were made of conch shell

Turquoise (a type of gemstone) was highly valued by the Aztecs